While recognising that the existence of the Foreign Office mind is important in ensuring proper analysis of how British foreign policy was formulated, this is not to say that all the officials of that department held a single view on all issues. They were, after all, individuals capable of forming their own opinions and debating important matters. The Foreign Office mind simply meant that these individuals shared certain values and that such debates, when they occurred, usually centred on nuances of policy, rather than the larger issues of British foreign affairs.[63] Likewise, it is also important to note that while little distinction has been made thus far between the Foreign Office and the foreign secretary, this does not mean that the two were one and the same. In fact, in the following chapters, Curzon's is the name which appears more than any other, including that of Hardinge or Crowe. The reason for this, as Chapter One will explain further, is simply that Curzon was pre-eminent when it came to British relations with South Asia in the post-war period. The various clerks and under-secretaries of the Foreign Office could offer intelligent and valuable advice to the head of their department, but they could not make him accept it.[64] And, as will come to be seen, Curzon was one who only paid heed to what he wanted to hear, often rejecting anything which did not fit with his predetermined plan of action. If Curzon dominates this book, it is a reflection of how he dominated Britain's relations with South Asia between 1918 and 1924.

Prestige

Having discussed the processes of Foreign Office thinking, it is important to look at what exactly officials were thinking about when it came to Britain's foreign relations. And the answer to that is simple – empire. The British Empire in the years after the First World War has been of interest to many scholars, largely because of the debate on the issue of decline which has dominated the historiography.[65] It has often been argued that the First World War set in motion the destruction of the empire by depleting Britain's financial resources to the point where it went from being the world's creditor to being a nation deeply in debt. This economic stress forced Britain to rapidly reduce its military expenditure and placed restrictions on